

Equity, Diversity and Inclusion

Diversity is an inherently complex issue and everyone makes their own trade-off between ideal equality and dealing with historical inequality. It is exciting to see that University of Calgary (UofC) explicitly emphasizes the importance of equity, diversity, and inclusion in the university campus. Issues of diversity and inequality are deeply important to me - both personally and professionally. I want to briefly include my own take on this topic alongside what I hope to do. Growing in a small colony in a big city Kolkata, India I always saw people in my colony are helpful and having brotherhood relations with neighbours. I raised up between people having different religions and that made me a liberal person in nature. Being born and raised up in a middle class family, I have directly experienced economic uncertainty, which manifested in part as periodic lack of access to proper education and health care. My family's navigation of our life experiences reminded me daily of the ways that social inequities affect opportunities and security. As a faculty member at Concordia University of Edmonton, I have been fortunate to have the opportunity to do so not only as an individual, but also as part of a larger whole. I believe that engineering education has an essential role in cultivating an engineering workforce to meet the needs of our diverse communities. My diverse educational background, multinational work experiences in Canada, USA, Mexico and India, I would bring additional insight to the diversity issues among diversified communities in UofC.

Multicultural Work Experience. I had the opportunity to work across different cultures and countries such as Canada, United States, Mexico, and India. The experience was enlightening as it enriched my perspective for research and advising. It also helped me appreciate the importance of diversity in science and engineering. Unfortunately, given the low representation of visually minor race in these fields, I believe mine was a very privileged experience. I am committed to achieving equity and enhancing diversity in science and engineering areas-ensuring that the representation of not only visually minor race, but also other minority groups is reflective of current times.

Creating Interactive Environment. I will strive to create a positive environment. This means I will highlight everyone's contributions, push shy or junior students to voice their opinions, speak up when there are subtle or blatant put-downs, support broad collaboration and encourage non-academic interests. These are minor details, but these everyday experiences do matter. For example, I started a chocolate fund that turned my office into a "watering hole" where students from every group on the floor comes to chat. Before this, cross-group interaction did not commonly occur. On a negative note, I have also seen students leave the graduate program because their group did not emphasize these qualities. My goal is for everyone passing through the university to accept that people vary widely along every attribute imaginable, and that this is valuable. By publicly applauding individual eccentricities, I hope that it can encourage students to do the same. For example, weekly trivia posters about different community members may have a positive effect.

Teaching. As an representative of the visually minor group, the experience helped me to recognize the barriers faced by minor and other minorities engaging in computer science. In my teaching, I take seriously the challenge of teaching to diverse audiences. I have found that my students have an enormous amount to teach me and I strive to learn from and to adapt both the style and content of my teaching material to reflect the diversity of my students. In organizing classes, seminars, and lectures, I have found that more diverse programs are able to attract, and communicate more effectively to, broad audiences. By bringing in a wide variety of perspectives, a more diverse program can also support broader, more widely applicable, and more memorable learning. I would love to see non-computer science students such as artists, political science students, or architects take and excel in computer science classes. Computer science classes have historically been considered abstract, intellectual subjects, however big data and data science classes teach practical tools that are useful in any discipline. In the future, I plan to use my expertise in designing massive online courses, to develop an online version of this program to reach out to underrepresented student groups in remote locations.

Advising. I mentor students on an ongoing basis, and on several occasions. I have received the very competitive basic science research fund to mentor and train individuals interested in pursuing research careers focused on discovering image based phenotypes that can substitute genomic biomarkers for making therapeutic and prognostic decisions of cancer and reduce the treatment cost. During my tenure as an assistant professor at CIMAT, Mexico mentored a student selected through competitive program "DELFIN" whose commitment is to developing future leaders in the field of artificial intelligence. All of my mentees in these aforementioned programs are from groups underrepresented in science and research.

My current efforts continue to reflect my commitment to enhancing diversity, equity and inclusion. I have a long-standing commitment towards reducing inequities in engineering as well as improving equity and diversity in University faculty recruitment and retention. Looking ahead to my new roles at the University, I intend to use my training, skills and position to ensure excellence and increase equity and diversity at my University and in society. I am very much interested to arrange such programs in future. I am an open-minded and liberal person in nature. I do not distinguish people by his/her sex, race, religion, political views or sexual orientation. I prefer to work in professional relationship but in a friendly way. My ongoing commitment to diversity, equity and inclusion is solid. Diversity, to me, is not just something to be achieved or talked about or theorized; it is the source of life for me. I declare myself that I will strongly follow and respect the equity and diversity policy of the university.